Amazon review: The Koran (Penguin Classics) N.J. Dawood (Introduction, Translator 2004)

Getting Away with Murder

Im rating the Koran, not this translation. ISIS is not perverting the message if Islam, they are doing exactly what the prophet did and what the Koran enjoins.

You have to know the doctrine of abrogation (16:3) - in case of conflict later verses replace earlier. You have to know the putative order of the verses. If you do that, you will understand the Koran just as Islamic jurists have understood it for 1000 yrs. Here is the 14th century Hanbali jurist , Ibn Taymiya: *"In ordering Jihad Allah has said: 'Fight them until there is no persecution and religion becomes Allah's'. Allah has, in fact, repeated this obligation [to fight] and has glorified jihad in most of the Medina suras he has stigmatized those who neglected to do so, and treated them as hypocrites an cowards. It is impossible to count the number of times when jihad and its virtues are extolled in the Book and the sunna. Jihad is the best form of voluntary service that man consecrates to Allah.*

Therefore, since jihad is divinely instituted, and its goal is that religion reverts in its entirety to Allah and to make Allah's word triumph, whoever opposes the realization of this goal will be fought, according to the unanimous opinion of Muslims. Jews and Christians as well as Zoroastrians, must be fought until they embrace Islam or pay the jizya without recriminations.

The wives of infidels must also be reduced to slavery and the possessions of infidels must be confiscated. It is lawful to besiege infidels in their towns and in their fortresses and to use flooding fire and the machines of war against them, and to attack the unawares at night, all of this without regard for the presence in their midst of Muslim prisoners or merchants for whom these means of mass destruction are equally dangerous. " Cited in Bat Ye'or Islam and Dhimmitude p 44,45

Here is a modern variant, strategist of the Muslim brotherhood Sayyid Qutb writes: "*When we understand the nature of Islam, ...we realize the inevitability of jihad, or striving for God's cause, taking a military form in addition to its advocacy form. We will further recognize that jihad was never defensive, in the narrow sense that the term 'defensive war' generally denotes today. It is this narrow sense that is emphasized by the defeatists who succumb to the pressure of the present circumstances and to the Orientalists; wily attacks.(p. 49,50). "As Islam works for peace, it is not satisfied with a cheap peace that applies only to the area where people of the Muslim happen to live. Islam aims to achieve the sort of peace which insures that all submission is made to God alone. This means that all people submit themselves to God, and none of them takes others for their lords. We must form our view on the basis of the ultimate stage of the Jihad movement, not on the early or middle stages of the prophet's mission*" (The Sayyid Qutb Reader A.J. Bergesen ed, Routeledge 2008, p.50)

This is the evident and obvious interpretation of verses like (there are many):
- *Kill them wherever you find them. Drive them out of the places from which they drove you.*

Idolatry is worse than carnage. (Koran 2 :193) [new edition "idolatry is more grievous than bloodshed"]
- "*Say 'To fight in this month is a grave offence; but to debar people from the path of God, to blaspheme against Him and against the Holy Mosque, and to expel its worshipers from it, is more grievous in God's sight. Idolatry is more grievous than bloodshed*"'(Koran 2, 217)
- "Fight *against them until idolatry is no more and Allah's religion reigns supreme*"(Koran 2 :193)
- "*Make war upon them until idolatry shall cease and God's religion shall reign supreme*". (Koran 8:40)...
- "*Enjoy therefore the good and lawful things which you have gained in war, and fear Allah.* "(Koran 8:68)
- "*When the sacred months are over slay the idolaters wherever you find them. Arrest them, besiege them, and lie in ambush everywhere for them".* (Koran 9:4)
- "*Fight against such of those to whom the Scriptures were given as believe neither in Allah nor in the Last day, who do not forbid what Allah and His apostle have forbidden, and do not embrace the true faith, until they pay tribute out of hand and are utterly subdued* "(Koran 9:26)
- *"If you do not fight, He will punish you sternly and replace you by other men"* (Koran 9:38)
- *"Believers, do not make friends with any men other than your own people.* "(Koran 3:117)
- *"Believers, do not make friends with those who are enemies of mine and yours"* (Koran, 60:1)
- *"Believers, do not befriend your fathers or your brothers if they choose unbelief in preference to faith"* (Koran, 9:19).
- "*Believers, Take neither Jews nor Christians for your friends. They are friends with one another. Whoever of you seeks their friendship shall become one of their number. Allah does not guide the wrongdoers.*" (Koran, 5:49)

I'll spare you most of the verses on women except one, which was revealed when one of the prophet's wives caught him, in her house on her night, copulating with his favorite Christian concubine:
- "*Prophet, why do you prohibit that which Allah has made lawful to you, in seeking to please your wives? Allah is forgiving and merciful. Allah has given you absolution from such oaths. Allah is your master. He is the Wise One the All-knowing. When the prophet confided a secret to one of his wives; and when she disclosed it and Allah informed him of this, he made known to her one part of it and said nothing about the other. And when he had acquainted her with it, she said Who told you this?' He replied The Wise One, the All-knowing , told me'. If you two turn to Allah in repentance (for your hearts have sinned) you shall be pardoned; but if you conspire against him, know that Allah is his protector, and Gabriel and the righteous among the faithful. The angels too are his helpers. It may well be that, if he divorce you, his Lord will give him in your place better wives than yourselves, submissive to Allah and full of faith, devout, penitent, obedient and given to fasting; both widows and virgins."* (Koran 66:1)

Mohammad also received verses relating his person:
- "*You [Muhammad] may have whomever you desire; there is no blame* "(Koran.33:51)
- *"Allah gives his Messenger Lordship and Power over whomever He wills"* (Koran.59:6)
- *"You [Muhammad] are an exalted character of tremendous morality. Soon you will see, and they will see which of you is afflicted with madness* "(Koran.68:4)

You'll also want to learn that the sun sets in a sea of black mud.(Koran 18:86), that you may not force your slave girls into prostitution (Koran 24:33), though of course slavery is allowed, that Allah changes wayward Jews into apes and pigs. (Koran 2:62, 5:57)

This all raises serious questions about religion and morality. Indeed the Old Testament is equally immoral, if less obsessive. The Catholic church has managed to discover the obligation of burning heretics and justification of slavery in the New Testament. Can an otherwise immoral act become moral because god commands it, or in so doing does god himself become immoral?

While our philosophers and ethicists debate the meaning of "good", the separation of mind and matter, whether turning my head is a voluntary act etc we let god get away with murder. We need to know more about the limbic system....of god worshippers and philosophers.